

Ajay Shankar

Senior Product Manager

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Summary

Product leader with 20+ years in **product strategy**, roadmap execution, and **digital transformation** across legacy-to-SaaS environments (3 years, 100,000+ annual customer journeys, 38 sites, 15 countries).

Track record of **growing** and leading multi-disciplinary **product and technology organisations**, establishing portfolio **governance**, **execution** discipline, **data-driven decision** making, and setting standards for **customer-focused delivery**. Experienced in partner ecosystem integration, AI-native and AI-ready products, and executive stakeholder management. Combines analytical rigour with business strategy. B.E. Mechanical Engineering, INSEAD MBA.

Experience

Senior Product Manager

EF Education First

Mar 2023 – Mar 2026

Zurich, Switzerland

- * **Product Strategy into Execution:** Owned the product roadmap for EF Language Abroad's platform serving operations teams, **digitally transforming processes, workflows and systems**, over 3 years, and across 100,000+ annual customer journeys; built the operating rhythm for **product planning and prioritization**.
- * **Execution Strategy:** Developed a 5-phase, 38 locations, 15-country and 18-month product rollout strategy, prioritising product features, selecting rollout locations and power users, **aligning these realities with company goals**.
- * **Hands-on Product Building:** Designed, built, shipped an AI-native app for the Football World Cup with 70+ live users; created and executed SQL scripts for data transformation during migration from legacy to a cloud platform.
- * **Revenue-focused Delivery:** Delivered a real-time inventory tool accessing new revenue channels by aligning cross-functional value streams (Design, Sales, Engineering, Marketing) to secure **executive team buy-in**, and laying the foundation for dynamic pricing.

Product Owner — Operations Systems

EF Education First

Jan 2019 – Mar 2023

Zurich, Switzerland

- * **Data-informed Product Work:** Owned product data and reporting, building actionable dashboards to indicate business and process health, driving increases in self-service, reducing case response and resolution cycles; resulting in customer onboarding time -60% and efficiency +24%.
- * **Stakeholder Management:** Presented customer feedback and process bottlenecks to newly created ambassador group, running **customer insight** and discovery cycles; prioritized self-service and customer focus, driving NPS +183%, and reducing onboarding time by 60% through evidence-based product decisions.
- * **Communication:** Presented at the Salesforce World Tour, and at annual management summits, running feature pre-views, and building **stakeholder alignment** for upcoming features across Sales, Operations, Design, and Engineering.

Project Manager / Operations Manager / Director — Worldwide IT Support

EF Education First

Jan 2007 – Dec 2018

Bengaluru, India / Zurich, Switzerland

- * **Organisation Building:** Grew the **multi-disciplinary** organisation from 130 to 325 professionals; established operating procedures, frameworks for engineering, support and quality as part of building a product technology hub; won "Best Service Department" four consecutive years.
- * **Operations & Scale:** Led 40-person team across 190 global locations; sustained 99.9% uptime through disciplined operating model and continuous improvement; managed €1.5mn budget and vendor contracts.

Senior Systems Analyst

Satyam Computer Services Pvt. Ltd.

Jun 2001 – Nov 2005

Chennai / Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia / Redmond, WA, USA

- * **Hands-On Delivery & Stakeholder Management:** Directed build and launch of Malaysia's first national digital health platform (Ministry of Health, 125+ clinics); managed testing and delivery for Microsoft's Certified Professional programme; awarded double promotion for performance.

Achievements

- * **Operating Model at Scale:** Led 3-year digital transformation and 5-phase, 18-month rollout across 15 countries and 38 sites, for 100,000+ annual customer journeys
- * **Multi-Disciplinary Organisation Growth:** Grew product and tech organisation from 130 to 325 staff; managed \$1.5mn budget
- * **User Insight & Outcome-Driven Prioritization:** Built ambassador-led user discovery practice; aligned prioritization to org. goals; achieved NPS +183%, OSAT +15%, onboarding time –60%
- * **Hands-On Product Depth:** Migrated legacy data to Cloud-based SaaS platform; built Power BI and CRM Analytics dashboards to drive data-informed decisions; built and launched AI-native app with 70+ live users
- * **Executive Communication & Alignment:** Presented at Salesforce World Tour and annual management summits; secured cross-functional buy-in for real-time inventory tool opening new revenue channel

Skills

Product Leadership: Product Strategy and Execution, Multi-Quarter Roadmap, Go-To-Market Strategy, Adoption Metrics, Prioritisation & Sequencing, Product Operations, Team Building.

Communication: Stakeholder Engagement, Executive Communication, Data-Informed Decision-Making, Cross-Functional Alignment, People Management, User Insight & Discovery, Ambassador Programmes.

Tools & Technical Skills: Agile (Certified Scrum), AI (Claude Code, Cursor), Jira, Confluence, Salesforce, SQL, Data Migration, Power BI, CRM Analytics.

Education

MBA <i>INSEAD</i>	2006 <i>Fontainebleau, France</i>
B.E. Mechanical Engineering <i>University of Madras</i>	1997 – 2001 <i>Chennai, India</i>

Languages

* **English** (Native) * **German** (B1 / working proficiency) * **French** (A1)

Certifications

* Certified Scrum Product Owner (CSPO) <i>Scrum Alliance</i>	2025 – 2028
* Vibe Coding with Cursor AI / Vibe Coding with Claude Code <i>Coursera</i>	2026